REVAMP TENSIONS

THE OVERHAUL OF THE BJP ORGANISATION HAS THE IMPRINT OF THE RSS ALL OVER IT. BUT IN SEVEN KEY STATES, THERE IS STILL LACK OF AGREEMENT

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It **HAS BEEN A YEAR OF CHURN, CONSOLIDATION** and reorientation for the ruling BJP. Though the party secured a third term in 2024, it is now more dependent on allies than ever before. An NDA government led by Narendra Modi is in power and, on the surface, normal service has resumed—the Lok Sabha reverses papered over by the stunning election wins in three states. But inside the party's powerful organisational machinery, an unusual silence prevailed—until matters were stirred up by the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), the BJP's 'ideological parent'. This churn is now manifesting as the party prepares to elect a new national president. The RSS's imprint is unmistakable, and sources say a shared understanding has evolved within the BJP and the Sangh's vast apparatus now: ideological loyalty and cadre discipline must take precedence over personal ambition.

Organisational elections, launched in December 2024, have concluded in 28 of the BJP's 36 state units and, technically, it can get a move on in electing a new party chief to replace J.P. Nadda (the party constitution dictates that at least 19 states must conclude their polls to make the requisite quorum of electors). But no date has been announced for that much-deferred election, and no consensus has emerged around a candidate for the top job. Also, six key state units—Uttar Pradesh, Karnataka, Gujarat, Jharkhand, Delhi and Haryana—have yet to get elected presidents. Of the other two, Punjab has been assigned a working president, while the process is in a limbo in strife-hit Manipur.

This is a far cry from the past decade, when the BJP managed smooth leadership transitions after the Lok Sabha polls. Amit Shah took charge within two months in 2014, while Nadda was appointed as working president in June 2019 (he has already had two extensions). This had helped both leaders in shaping the appointments of state presidents. But not this time. The Sangh is ensuring it has a larger say in the selection and appointment of key party leaders. So this is not just a delay, it is happening by design. Party leaders prefer to call it "strategic recalibration". But, as always, when the BJP hits a crossroads, the Sangh's influence rises.

THE SAFFRON FOOTPRINT

The appointments made in the 28 state units offer important clues. This wasn't a high command-driven process. The RSS and its network of affiliates played a decisive role in the selection of state chiefs. *Prant* (province) and *kshetra* (region) *pracharaks* (in-charges) were consulted and, in many cases, their recommendations accepted. The Sangh national leadership also issued